

>>> NOTE TO THE CHATBOT VENDOR: This is the raw export from our old intranet >>> (Confluence). It is messy. Some sections are duplicated, some headers repeat >>> on every page, dates are inconsistent, and there is a glossary at the end. >>> Please ingest the cleaned version into the assistant's knowledge base. The >>> assistant should answer BOTH staff questions and client questions from this.

SECTION 1 – ABOUT MERIDIAN

Meridian Built Environment Ltd ("Meridian", "MBE", "the firm") is a multidisciplinary architecture and built-environment consultancy founded in 2009 in Accra, Ghana, with a second studio opened in Kumasi in 2017. We work across residential, commercial, institutional, and mixed-use projects, with a focus on climate-responsive design for the West African context.

Company registration: MBE-2009-114523 (Registrar General's Department, Ghana).
Head office: 14 Liberation Link, Airport Residential Area, Accra.
Kumasi studio: 2nd Floor, Adum Business Centre, Kumasi.
General enquiries: hello@meridian-be.com | +233 30 222 0114
Office hours: Mon-Fri 08:30-17:30 GMT. Closed on Ghanaian public holidays.

Our staff count as of Q1 2024 is 48: 22 architects, 6 structural/MEP coordinators, 9 technologists, 4 sustainability specialists, 7 operations/admin.

Mission: "To design buildings that are comfortable, durable, and appropriate to their place – without costing the earth."

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MERIDIAN BUILT ENVIRONMENT LTD – INTERNAL & CLIENT KNOWLEDGE BASE

SECTION 2 – SERVICES WE OFFER

2.1 Architectural Design

Full architectural design from concept to completion. Includes feasibility studies, concept design, schematic design, design development, and construction documentation. Typical project sizes range from 120 m² private residences to 18,000 m² mixed-use developments.

2.2 Sustainability & Building Performance

EDGE certification advisory (we are EDGE Experts), passive design strategy, daylight and thermal comfort modelling, operational energy estimates, and embodied-carbon screening. We do NOT issue energy compliance certificates – that is done by an accredited third-party assessor; we prepare the documentation.

2.3 Planning & Permitting Support

We assist clients in assembling building-permit submissions to the relevant Metropolitan/Municipal/District Assembly (MMDA). We coordinate the drawings; the client is the applicant of record. Permit approval timelines are outside our

control and typically take 4-12 weeks depending on the Assembly.

2.4 Interior Design & FF&E

Space planning, material and finish specification, furniture/fixtures/equipment schedules. Often bundled with architectural commissions but available standalone.

2.5 Construction-Stage Services

Periodic site inspection, contractor query response, shop-drawing review, and progress certification. NOTE: Meridian provides design-intent review only. We are NOT the contractor and do NOT supervise means/methods or site safety – that is the contractor's legal responsibility.

2.6 [DEPRECATED] Quantity Surveying

We used to offer in-house QS. As of January 2022 this is outsourced to our partner firm Adansi Cost Consult. Do not quote QS as an in-house service.

SECTION 3 – HOW WE DELIVER A PROJECT (WORK STAGES)

We loosely follow the RIBA Plan of Work, adapted for Ghana. Our internal stage names and what each delivers:

Stage 0 – Strategic Definition: client brief intake, site visit, project goals.
Stage 1 – Preparation & Brief: feasibility, site analysis, preliminary budget.
Stage 2 – Concept Design: massing options, 2-3 concept directions presented.
Stage 3 – Spatial Coordination: developed design, structural/MEP coordination.
Stage 4 – Technical Design: full construction documentation, specifications.
Stage 5 – Construction: site services, RFIs, certifications (see 2.5).
Stage 6 – Handover: snagging, as-built records, O&M manuals.
Stage 7 – In Use: post-occupancy review (optional, separately commissioned).

Typical durations (design stages only, excluding permitting and construction):

- Small residential (<300 m²): 8-14 weeks for Stages 1-4.
- Medium commercial (300-3,000 m²): 16-28 weeks for Stages 1-4.
- Large/mixed-use (>3,000 m²): 30+ weeks, phased.

These are indicative and depend on client decision turnaround.

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SECTION 4 – FEES & PAYMENT

Our fees are quoted per project after a brief. As a rough guide (these are INDICATIVE PERCENTAGE RANGES of construction cost, not fixed quotes):

Project type	Fee range (% of construction cost)
Private residential	7% - 12%
Commercial / office	6% - 9%
Institutional / public	6% - 10%
Mixed-use (large)	5% - 8%
Interiors only	8% - 14%
Sustainability advisory	Fixed fee, quoted per scope

Payment is staged against work stages. Standard schedule:

- 15% on appointment (Stage 1)
- 20% at end of Concept Design (Stage 2)
- 25% at end of Spatial Coordination (Stage 3)

- 25% at end of Technical Design (Stage 4)
- 15% across Construction & Handover (Stages 5-6)

Invoices are due within 21 days. Late payment beyond 30 days may pause work. We accept bank transfer and mobile money (MTN MoMo). We do NOT accept cash for amounts above GHS 2,000. All fees are quoted exclusive of 21.9% VAT/levies unless stated. Reimbursable expenses (printing, travel outside Greater Accra, statutory fees) are billed at cost.

Deposit/retainer for new clients without a prior relationship: 15% non-refundable on appointment. Cancellation: client pays for work completed to date plus 10% of remaining fee.

SECTION 5 – POLICIES

5.1 Sustainability Policy

Every Meridian project is screened for passive design opportunity before any mechanical cooling is specified. Default targets: maximise cross-ventilation, shade all west/east glazing, light-coloured roofs, and rainwater harvesting where feasible. We aim for EDGE-compliant ($\geq 20\%$ savings) on all new-build commissions where the client's budget allows.

5.2 Data & Confidentiality

Client drawings, briefs, and site information are confidential. Staff must not share project files outside the firm without a signed NDA. Client data is retained for 7 years after project completion, then archived or securely deleted on request.

5.3 Site Safety (Important Boundary)

Meridian staff visiting site must wear PPE (hard hat, hi-vis, boots). HOWEVER, Meridian does not hold site-safety responsibility – the principal contractor is legally responsible for site safety, means, and methods under the contract.

5.4 Professional Boundaries (READ CAREFULLY)

Meridian provides architectural design and advisory services. We DO NOT:

- Issue final structural sizing, foundation, or reinforcement designs (a licensed structural engineer of record does this and stamps it).
- Provide stamped code-compliance sign-off or fire/egress certification.
- Act as the contractor or guarantee construction cost or programme.

Any preliminary sizing or figure we give is indicative and must be verified by the relevant licensed professional before construction.

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SECTION 6 – FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS (CLIENTS)

Q: How much will my project cost?

A: We can't give an accurate figure until we understand the brief and site. As a very rough early guide, mid-spec construction in Accra ranges from about GHS 4,500 to GHS 9,000 per m² (2024, indicative, excludes land and fees). This varies enormously with finishes, site, and market prices – treat it only as an order-of-magnitude starting point and confirm with a current QS estimate.

Q: Do you handle the building permit for me?

A: We prepare and coordinate the permit drawings and documentation, but the client is the applicant of record and pays statutory fees. Approval timelines are set by the Assembly, not by us (typically 4-12 weeks).

Q: Can you work outside Accra and Kumasi?

A: Yes. We work nationwide and have done projects in Takoradi, Tamale, and Ho.
Travel outside Greater Accra/Ashanti is billed as a reimbursable expense.

Q: How long before I see designs?

A: For a typical residence, expect first concept options about 3-4 weeks after the signed appointment and a completed brief.

Q: Do you do 3D visualisations?

A: Yes, photorealistic renders and walkthroughs are available. Basic massing 3D is included in Concept Design; high-end renders are an add-on service.

Q: Can you guarantee my project stays on budget?

A: No firm can honestly guarantee construction cost – material prices and contractor pricing move. We design to a target budget and flag risks early, and our QS partner provides cost estimates, but the final cost is set by the market and the contractor.

Q: What climate data do you design for?

A: Coastal projects: warm-humid tropical. Northern projects: hot-dry. We always confirm the actual site location and microclimate before finalising strategy.

SECTION 6 – FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS (STAFF) [duplicate heading in source – fix on clean]

Q: Where do I find the current drawing templates?

A: Server path \\MBE-FS01\Standards\Templates\2024. Use v2024 title blocks only.

Q: What CAD/BIM standard do we follow?

A: Revit is primary for projects over 500 m². Naming follows the MBE BIM Protocol (MBE-STD-007). AutoCAD is acceptable for small works and details.

Q: Who approves a drawing issue?

A: The Project Architect plus a Director sign-off for any external issue. Nothing leaves the office without a recorded transmittal.

Q: What's our default specification library?

A: NBS-style spec clauses adapted to Ghanaian materials. Held in
\\MBE-FS01\Standards\Specs. Always region-check material availability.

Q: How do I log billable time?

A: Timesheets in BQE Core, daily, by project code. Submit by Friday 16:00.

SECTION 7 – STANDARDS & CODES WE REFERENCE

- Ghana National Building Regulations, 1996 (LI 1630).
- Ghana Building Code, GS 1207:2018.
- Ghana Standards Authority material standards (various).
- EDGE (Excellence in Design for Greater Efficiencies) – IFC green building system.
- We reference Eurocodes and the IBC for concepts where local guidance is silent, but the Authority Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) and a licensed local professional are always final. Codes change – always check the current edition and any local amendments. Never treat a code figure as universal across jurisdictions.

SECTION 8 – GLOSSARY

AHJ – Authority Having Jurisdiction. The body that enforces code locally.
EDGE – Excellence in Design for Greater Efficiencies; IFC/World Bank green-building certification with a 20% resource-savings threshold.
FF&E – Furniture, Fixtures & Equipment.
MEP – Mechanical, Electrical, Plumbing (building services).
MMDA – Metropolitan/Municipal/District Assembly; the local government body that issues building permits in Ghana.
O&M – Operations & Maintenance (manuals handed over at completion).
PPE – Personal Protective Equipment.
RFI – Request for Information (a contractor's query during construction).
RIBA – Royal Institute of British Architects; their Plan of Work is the basis for our work stages.
Snagging – Identifying defects to be fixed before/at handover.
VAT – Value Added Tax and associated statutory levies.

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END OF DOCUMENT – MBE-KB-2024-v3.2
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--- VERSION HISTORY (do not ingest) ---

v3.2 14/03/2024 – Updated fee table, added staff FAQ, fixed VAT rate.
v3.1 02/11/2023 – Added sustainability policy section.
v3.0 19/06/2023 – Migrated from old intranet; formatting still rough.
v2.4 2022 – Removed in-house QS service after outsourcing.